In the second crucial meeting, Narayanan and Karan were seated across from the Prime Minister. The PM deliberately asked a twisted question—whether the LTTE had claimed responsibility for the assassination. Narayanan politely denied it, adding that a caller from Sacramento in California had called the office of *IndiaWest*, an Indian ethnic weekly published from California, and 'claimed responsibility on behalf of the LTTE'. That meant nothing to suggest that the LTTE had claimed responsibility.

Both Karan and Narayanan knew where it was coming from. Karan added another incident that had raised eyebrows. The Indian High Commission in Colombo had received a call around 4 p.m. on 21 May, about six hours before the assassination. The anonymous caller had asked whether Rajiv Gandhi was still alive. The junior High Commission staff member who had received the call had asked the caller to repeat his question, and the caller had complied. Then the staff member had asked the caller to identify himself, and the caller had quickly hung up. The PM was shocked to hear this, though he didn't miss the meaningful smile on Narayanan's face. Had it been brought to notice on time, perhaps Rajiv Gandhi's life could have been saved—at the least, security around him could have been tightened. The PM then told the two how Bajpai had been ruling out the LTTE or any Sri Lanka angle in the assassination.

The PM angrily pressed a phone button and asked to get Bajpai back to the PM's office. Sensing the situation might become aggravated, both Narayanan and Karan tried to placate the PM—they requested him to speak to Bajpai after their meeting was over. The PM understood. But there was more to the LTTE connections that both the senior officers wanted to discuss with the PM. They were armed with newspaper clippings, wire messages and phone-tapping reports, and started presenting their case.

Karan tabled a news clip of an article by Sri Lankan Tamil journalist D.B. Jayaraj, which had been carried in *The Hindu*. The writer had given the various aliases and other details of that kurta-pyjama man masquerading as a journalist at the site before the blast. This was after the paper's publication of the photograph of the suspected assassin. The PM laughed